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SAN FERNANDO VALLEY - Acosta leads; other incumbents hold Assembly seats

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Assemblyman Dante Acosta on Wednesday continued his grip on a small lead over Democrat Christy Smith in the race for a statehouse district that spans two counties and three valleys, while three other local Assembly incumbents held on to win their seats — all with 100 percent of precincts reporting.

In the case of Acosta, with a narrow 1,222-vote lead over Smith, it appeared — if that number holds up — he was going to keep a Republican hold on the 38th Assembly seat, which spans the L.A. and Ventura county border and covers parts of the San Fernando, Santa Clarita and Simi valleys.

Acosta and Smith battled on political terrain marked with charges that Acosta was an extreme conservative in the guise of a moderate, even as he called for electing more Republicans to the statehouse to block Democrats' supermajority lock on passing tax laws without GOP votes. But it was that very Democratic majority in the Assembly — of which Smith wanted to be a part — that she argued could bring home benefits to the district.

Across the San Fernando Valley, Democratic Assembly incumbents held on to their seats, with no significant changes from early Wednesday morning results, according to the Secretary of State's office.

With all precincts in, Jesse Gabriel has 67.6 percent of the vote to his challenger, Republican Justin Clark's 32.4 percent for the 45th Assembly District, in the west San Fernando Valley. They were seeking a full two-year term to represent a district that stretches from Chatsworth to Calabasas.

Gabriel is already representing the district because he had won an earlier special election to complete the unexpired term for that seat, after the previous Assemblyman, Matt Debabneh, stepped down following allegations of sexual misconduct

Clark, a 19-year-old Calabasas resident who works at a local ice cream shop, said his goals, if elected, included tackling waste and corruption in state government. They were messages that resonated in the primary in June.

Clark said Tuesday evening that he would be "very proud" if his campaign garners similar results as in the primary election, or better. In the last election, the percentage of votes he brought in "easily beat Republican voter registration," he said.

This was due to "our message of bipartisanship and focusing on the issues that matter most to local residents," he said. "We put people ahead of politics. My only regret is that we lacked the funding to spread our positive message further then we did."

But in a year when the shadow of President Trump's hardline immigration policies blanketed California's political landscape, voters appeared to side with Gabriel's pushback on those policies.

Gabriel, 37, has sued the Trump administration in two cases aimed at continuing protections under President Barack Obama's Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals policy for people who illegally immigrated to the United States at a young age. His priorities goals include increasing access to a good education and protecting the environment.

In the central portion of the San Fernando Valley, Democrat Adrin Nazarian held on against Republic challenger Roxanne Hoge for Assembly District 46, which encompasses areas including North Hills, Panorama City, Van Nuys

and North Hollywood. Nazarian was up 77.9 percent to Hoge's 22.1 percent.

Like Acosta, Hoge, 52, campaigned on cutting taxes and regulation while protecting Proposition 13. But it wasn't enough in the central and southern portions of the San Fernando Valley, where Nazarian's message of adding entertainment industry jobs and beefing up public infrastructure resonated with voters.

• To see updated results on Tuesday's election, go here.

Not far away, in the 39th Assembly District — stretching from Sylmar and Sunland-Tujunga to North Hollywood — Luz Rivas, a Democrat, was well on her way to an official win to represent a seat left up for grabs after Raul Bocanegra resigned amid allegations of sexual harassment. Rivas had already won a special election in June to fill out Bocanegra's term, and was seeking the full term in Tuesday's general election. As of afternoon Wednesday, Rivas was ahead of Republican challenger Ricardo Benitez, 75.6 percent to 24.4 percent.

Rivas, the founder of San Fernando Valley-based nonprofit DIY Girls, advocated help for small businesses, more affordable housing and improving social service programs.

"I feel good," Rivas said late Tuesday evening. "I feel confident that the voters of the 39th district are re-electing me. I'm very excited to represent them in a full term in the Assembly."

Rivas said she had just come back from the election night party of Gavin Newsom, who was celebrating his victory in the governor's race.

"The energy there felt very good," she said. "There's good things to come for California under his leadership and under the state legislature."

Staff reporter Kevin Modesti and local editor Ryan Carter contributed to this report.

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